

Final Report

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Group Project Topic:

The Art of Ridge Decorations in Chen Clan Ancestral Hall – A Cultural Perspective

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A Study on Representative Ridge Beasts in Different Regions of China

1 Introduction

In our group project, we researched the art of ridge decorations in the Chen Clan Ancestral Hall, a typical Lingnan ancestral hall. We concluded four interesting findings on the symbolic meanings and inference of ridge decorations. Ridge decorations have multiple forms such as ridge beasts and sculptures with stories in different materials. In this essay, we limit our study to the ridge beasts with an emphasis on the ridge beasts in various regions of China. In northern China, ridge beasts in palace architecture follow the hierarchy principle, while ridge beasts in dwellings and religious buildings have rich patterns in dragon shape. In southern China, particularly in Lingnan, a typical ridge beast pattern is Ao fish, which has symbolic meanings and functions. In Yunnan, the tile cat has a special design for the intention of warding off evils.

2 Overview of Ridge Beasts

The ridge beast is a functional structure located at the ridges of Chinese architecture, in the shape of beasts¹. The materials of ridge beasts include tile, pottery, and clay, varying by location. Originally, ridge beasts appeared at the two ends of ridges, to protect the wood or metal structures of ridges from corruptions and rustness². Apart from structural functions, ridge beasts are usually rich in emblems. Common animals used for ridge beasts include dragons, phoenixes, fish, birds, lions, tigers, horses, monkeys, and cattle³, with different symbolic meanings in traditional Chinese culture. Additionally, ridge beasts can be classified as Chiwen (also known

¹ Lina Yuan 袁麗娜, "Qiantan Zhongguo Chuantong Gujianzhu Zhong De Wujishou 淺談中國傳統古建築中的屋脊獸 [A brief discussion on ridge beasts in traditional Chinese architecture]," *Heilongjiang Shizhi* 黑龍江史志, no. 336 (2014): 59.

² Yuan, "Qiantan Zhongguo Chuantong," 59.

³ Qingzhou Wu 吳慶洲, "Zhongguo Gujianzhu Jishi De Wenhua Yuanyuan Chutan 中國古建築脊飾的文化淵源初探 [A preliminary study on the cultural origins of ridge decorations in ancient Chinese architecture]," *Huazhong jianzhu* 華中建築 15, no. 2 (1997): 28-31.

as Zhengwen, 鴟吻/正吻), located at the two ends of the main ridge; Chui Beast (垂獸) and Qiang Beast (戩獸), located at the ends of diagonal ridges, mainly Chui ridge (垂脊) and Qiang ridge (戩脊); Walking Beast (走獸) and Fairies (仙人), located at the corner ridges (角脊); Cover Beast (套獸), covering the corner beams⁴ (figure 1&2).

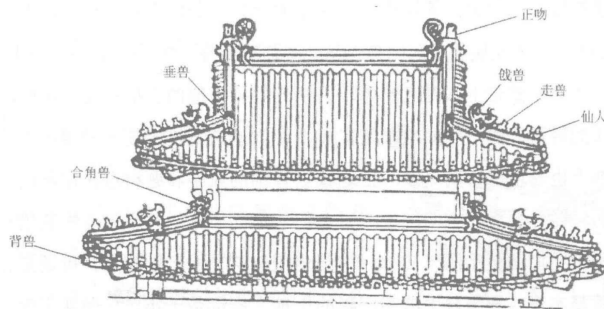


Figure 1. Classifications of ridge beasts, 2009.
Source: Xu, "Zhongguo Gujianzhu."

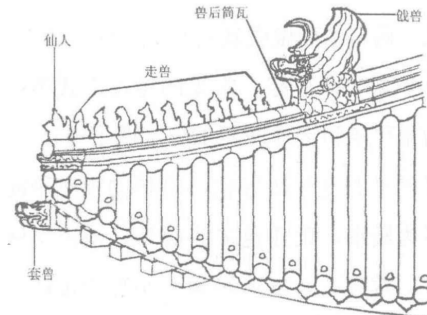


Figure 2. Positions of ridge beasts, 2009.
Source: Xu, "Zhongguo Gujianzhu."

In this essay, we apply the Mount Qin – Huai River (秦嶺淮河) to separate the Northern and Southern parts of China, and we will discuss the ridge beasts in these two regions respectively.

3 Ridge Beasts in Northern China

We will discuss the palace architecture, dwellings, and religious buildings respectively.

3.1 Palace Architecture – Hall of Supreme Harmony in Forbidden City

Ridge beasts in palace architecture obey the strict rule of hierarchy and order, particularly in the Forbidden City, and can be investigated through the number of walking beasts. Take the Hall of Supreme Harmony (太和殿) as an example, as the most noble hall in the forbidden city, it has the most sophisticated ridge beast design among palace halls. The number of walking beasts varies for the scale and ranking of the hall, while common numbers are one, three, five, seven, and nine. Nine is the most noble number in ancient Chinese culture, which is highly related to the daily life of the emperor, hence, halls used for handling governance affairs, resting, and meeting audiences, such as Qianqing Hall (乾清宮), Zhonghe Hall (中和殿), Baohe Hall (保和殿), contain nine walking beasts on the ridges⁵. However, the number of walking beasts

⁴ Hui Xu 許慧, "Zhongguo Gujianzhu Wuding Jishi Yanjiu 中國古建築屋頂脊飾研究 [A study of roof decorations in traditional Chinese architecture]" (master diss., Henan University, 2009).

⁵ Fan Xu 徐凡, Hao Qian 錢皓, and Yimin Wang 王一珉, "Lun Beijing Gugong Jianzhu Zhong Jishou De Tedian Ji Wenhuanneihan 論北京故宮建築中脊獸的特點及文化內涵 [Exploring the architectural features and cultural connotations of ridge beasts in the Forbidden City]," Gongye sheji 工業設計, (2017): 83.

at the Hall of Supreme Harmony has exceeded nine. There are ten walking beasts listed in order: dragon, phoenix, lion, god horse, sea horse, lion, fish, Xiezhi (獬豸), cattle, and Hangshi (行什, ranked number 10), symbolizing perfect (十全十美)⁶ (figure 3). The number of walking beasts resonates with the ranking of the hall, revealing the strict hierarchy in the palace architecture.

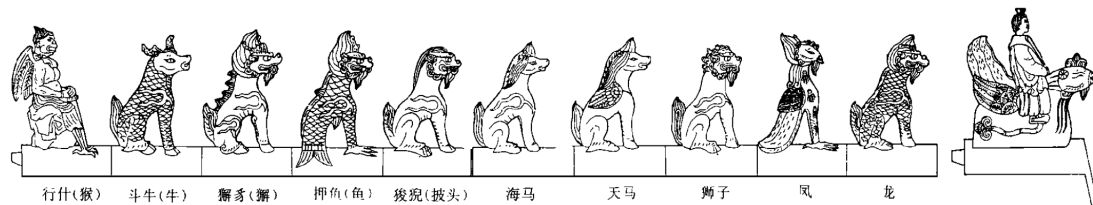


Figure 3. Walking beasts on the ridge of the Hall of Supreme Harmony, 1997.

Source: Wu, "Zhongguo Gujianzhu Jishi."

3.2 Dwellings and Religious Buildings – Shanxi

Dragon shape is common in ridge beasts in dwellings and religious buildings in northern China⁷. We investigate some examples in Shanxi. Shanxi is famous for its advanced glaze (琉璃) industry originated in the Han Dynasty. In Bei Dynasty, glaze craftsmanship has been extended to ridge decorations⁸. Dragon-shaped ridge beasts in Shanxi are rich in patterns and shape, especially in the Yuan, Ming, and Qing Dynasties. There are ridge beasts with dragon heads and fish bodies (figure 4), with a pawn reaching forward (figure 5), and with a phoenix combined with the dragon (figure 6).



Figure 4. Ridge beast with dragon head and fish body in Yuan Dynasty, 2009.

Source: Xu, "Zhongguo Gujianzhu."



Figure 5. Ridge beast with the dragon pawn reaching forward in Song-Jin Dynasty, 2009.

Source: Xu, "Zhongguo Gujianzhu."



Figure 6. Ridge beast with a phoenix combined with the dragon in Qing Dynasty, 2009.

Source: Xu, "Zhongguo Gujianzhu."

⁶ Xu, Qian, and Wang, "Lun Beijing Gugong," 84.

⁷ Qingzhou Wu 吳慶洲, "Zhongguo Gujianzhu Jishi De Wenhua Yuanyuan Chutan – Xu1 中國古建築脊飾的文化淵源初探 – 續 1 [A preliminary study on the cultural origins of ridge decorations in ancient Chinese architecture – Cont.1]," *Huazhong jianzhu 華中建築* 15, no. 3 (1997): 19.

⁸ Xu, "Zhongguo Gujianzhu."

Notice that for the dynasties mentioned in the above figures, the capitals are located in northern China, particularly, around Beijing city. Which is close to Shanxi. It can be conjectured that the dragon shape is widely used in dwellings and religious buildings in Shanxi because Shanxi is close to the center of right and ruling. The dragon, as an emblem of empirical right, is widely used for the worship of imperial power in public.

4 Ridge Beasts in Southern China

We will mainly discuss the ridge beasts in Lingnan and Yunnan dwellings, with interesting patterns and symbolic meanings.

4.1 Lingnan Dwellings

As discussed in the group project, dwellings in Lingnan have abundant ridge decorations, especially in some family ancestral halls, such as the Chen Clan ancestral hall. For the ridge beasts, the fish pattern is commonly used⁹. The representative Chiwen pattern in Lingnan dwellings is Ao fish (鰲魚). In the Chen Clan ancestral hall, every main ridge has two Ao fish standing upside down (figure 7). Similar patterns can be found in the Foshan Ancestral Temple (figure 8&9).

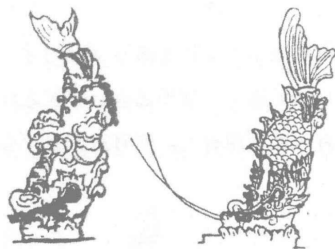


Figure 7. Ao fish in Chen Clan Ancestral Hall, 2009.
Source: Xu, "Zhongguo Gujianzhu."

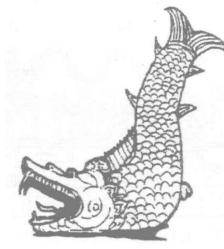


Figure 8. Ao fish in Foshan Ancestral Temple, 2009.
Source: Xu, "Zhongguo Gujianzhu."



Figure 9. Ao fish in Foshan Ancestral Temple, 2009.
Source: Xu, "Zhongguo Gujianzhu."

Unlike the Chiwen in northern China located at the two ends of the main ridges, Ao fish is usually placed in the middle of the main ridge, with a more three-dimensional and vivid pattern. On the other hand, as a water-living animal which is commonly seen in the daily life of Lingnan people, fish possesses the property of element water in Chinese Five-Element Philosophy (五行說), which can restrict fire. Placing a fish pattern on the roof symbolizes fireproofing for the

⁹ Wu, "Zhongguo Gujianzhu Jishi." 19.

architecture¹⁰. Ao fish can also represent academic achievement and the pursuit of fame and career in some ancient Chinese stories, bearing good hope for the Lingnan people ¹¹.

4.2 Yunnan Dwellings

Locating in the southwestern part of China, Yunnan has diverse cultures created by local minor ethnics. There is a special ridge beast in Yunnan, called tile cat (瓦貓), usually in the shape of a cat with its mouth opened exaggeratedly. Tile cat originates from the image of the tiger, which is regarded as the protection god, and can chase off evil beasts to protect people¹². The materials of tile cat include clay, pottery, glaze, and mud, while the shapes and patterns vary from region to region. Materials and patterns are largely affected by regional ethnic culture (Figures 10&11). The tile cat is always opening its mouth for the purpose of scaring and threatening evil beasts away.



Figure 10. Kunming tile cat, 2023.
Source: Xue and Li, "Kunming Wamao Zaoxing. "



Figure 11. Dali tile cat model, 2025. Photograph by the author.



Figure 12. Dali tile cat model, 2025. Photograph by the author.

5 Conclusion

In this essay, we discuss some representative ridge beasts in Chinese architecture. Ridge beasts in palace architecture in northern China obey strict rules of hierarchy, while the number of

¹⁰ Junjun Luo 蘿筠筠 and Yonghao Liang 梁永浩, "Dui Wenhua Fuhao De Jicheng Yu Zaichuangzao – Mingqing Zhushanjiao Aoyu Jishou Xingxiang Chuyi 對文化符號的繼承與再創造 – 明清珠三角鰲魚脊獸形象芻議 [Heritage and reinvention of cultural symbols: A study of the Ao fish ridge beast in the Pearl River Delta during Ming-Qing Period]," *Guangxi daxue xuebao* 廣西大學學報, no. 5 (2024): 167.

¹¹ Siping Zeng 曾思平, *Chen Shi Shuyuan Jianzhu Zhuangshi Zhong De Gushi He Chuanshuo* 陳氏書院建築裝飾中的故事和傳說 [Stories and Legends in the Architectural Decorations of the Chen Clan Academy] (Beijing: Wenwu chubanshe, 2022), 22.

¹² Xiaoxi Xue 薛曉西 and Ling Li 李凌, "Kunming Wamao Zaoxing Tezheng Ji Wenhua Neihan Duibi Yanjiu 昆明瓦貓造型特徵及文化內涵對比研究 [A comparative study on the stylistic features and cultural significance of Kunming's tile cats]," *Tianye diaocha* 田野調查, no. 6 (2023): 106.

walking beasts reveals the ranking of the palace hall. In dwellings and religious buildings in northern China, we conclude that the dragon pattern is commonly used as ridge beasts with diverse shapes and features. In southern China, we analyze the fish pattern in Lingnan dwellings for its symbolic meanings and function. We also mention a special ridge beast in Yunnan, tile cat, for its interesting design to ward off evil spirits.

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